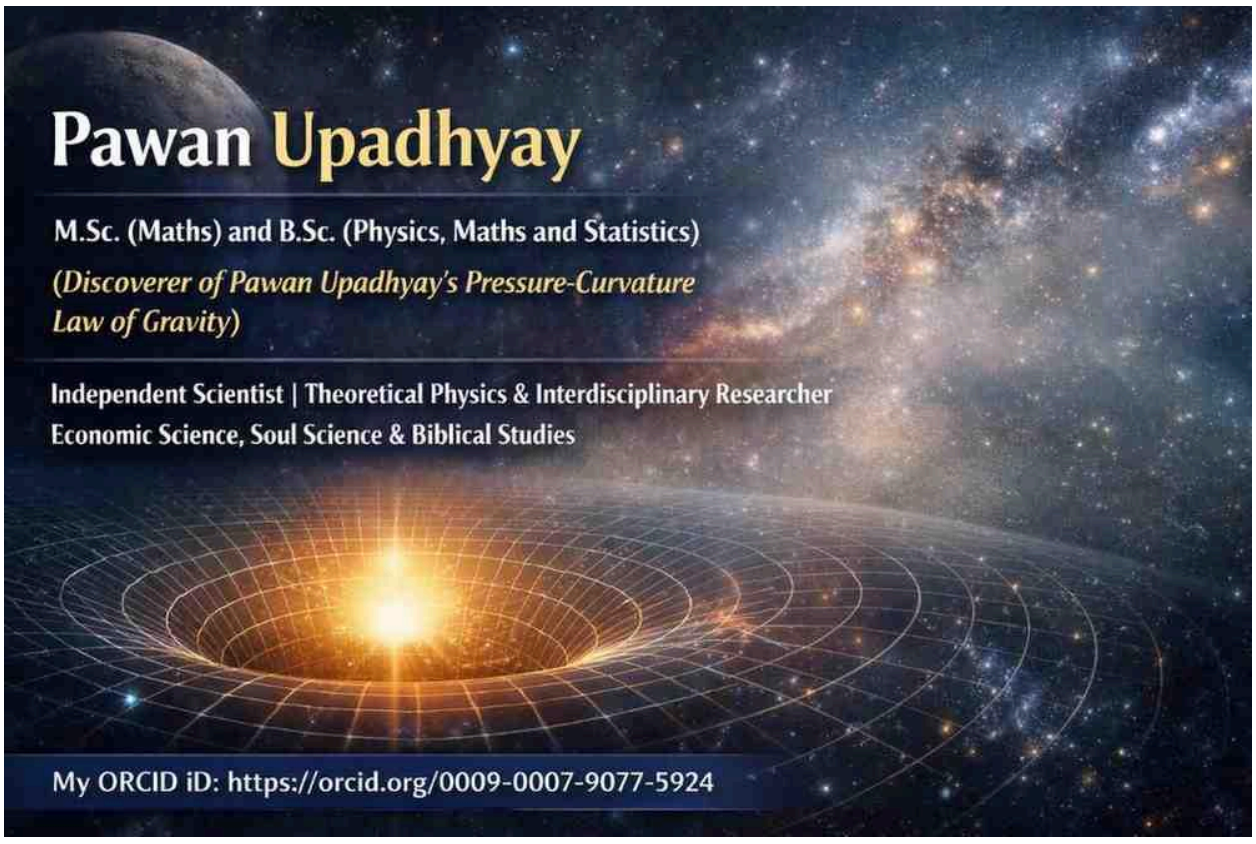
God and Lord in the Old and New Testaments

A Lexical and Christological Study of *Elohim*, *YHWH*, *Adonai*, *Theos*, and *Kyrios*

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Abstract

The biblical distinction between the terms “God” and “Lord” is central to understanding biblical monotheism and New Testament Christology. English translations, however, can obscure

important distinctions present in the original Hebrew and Greek. This paper examines the principal Hebrew terms ʾ**ēl**, ʾ**ĕlōhîm**, **YHWH**, and ʾ**ādôn/**ʾ**ădōnāy**, followed by the Greek terms **theos** and **kyrios**. Particular attention is given to the use of *kyrios* in the Septuagint and New Testament, where the term can function as the Greek representation of the divine name YHWH. The study then examines significant passages including Deuteronomy 6:4, Psalm 110:1, Isaiah 45:23, Joel 2:32, 1 Corinthians 8:6, Romans 10:9–13, Philippians 2:9–11, John 1:1–18, and John 20:28. The evidence demonstrates that “God” and “Lord” are not two mutually exclusive categories in biblical usage. Rather, the New Testament distinguishes the Father and Jesus while simultaneously assigning Jesus the title *Kyrios* and, in key passages, explicitly identifying Him with divine status. The paper concludes that the confession “Jesus Christ is Lord” must be interpreted within the theological and linguistic world of Israel's Scriptures and early Christianity.

Keywords: God, Lord, YHWH, Yahweh, Elohim, Adonai, Theos, Kyrios, Jesus Christ, Christology, Septuagint, New Testament, monotheism

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1. Introduction

The confession **“Jesus Christ is Lord”** occupies a central position in early Christianity. Paul declares that “Jesus Christ is Lord” in Philippians 2:11, while Romans 10:9 associates salvation with confessing Jesus as Lord. The Gospel of John records Thomas addressing the risen Jesus as **“My Lord and my God”** (John 20:28).

These statements raise an important linguistic and theological question:

What is the difference between “God” and “Lord” in the Bible, and what does it mean that Jesus Christ is called “Lord”?

The question cannot be answered adequately by examining English translations alone. The Old Testament was written primarily in Hebrew and Aramaic, while the New Testament was written in Greek. Moreover, the early Christians inherited the Greek Scriptures commonly known as the Septuagint, in which the Hebrew divine name YHWH was frequently represented by **kyrios**, “Lord.”

Consequently, the study of “God” and “Lord” involves three related questions:

1. What do the original Hebrew terms mean?
2. How did the Greek *kyrios* develop as a designation for God?
3. How does the New Testament apply this terminology to Jesus?

The purpose of this paper is not merely to define words but to investigate how these words function within the biblical theological framework.

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2. Methodology

This study uses a combination of:

- lexical analysis of Hebrew and Greek terminology;
- examination of significant Old Testament passages;
- comparison with their use in the Septuagint;
- analysis of New Testament quotations and allusions;
- consideration of scholarly discussion concerning *kyrios* Christology;
- distinction between lexical meaning and theological interpretation.

A fundamental methodological caution is necessary.

A word does not possess one rigid meaning in every occurrence. **Context determines meaning.** The Greek word *kyrios*, for example, can mean “lord,” “master,” “owner,” or “sir,” depending on context. It is therefore insufficient to argue that every occurrence of *kyrios* automatically means YHWH.

At the same time, the biblical and Septuagintal contexts demonstrate that *kyrios* can carry explicit divine significance.

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3. “God” in the Old Testament

3.1 The Hebrew term *ʾēl*

The Hebrew noun **ʾēl (אֵל)** is one of the ancient Semitic terms associated with deity.

It can refer to God and, depending on context, can also function in broader discussions of divine beings.

In biblical usage, *ʾēl* frequently occurs as a designation of Israel's God.

Examples include:

- Genesis 14:18 — *El Elyon*, “God Most High”
- Genesis 17:1 — *El Shaddai*
- Isaiah 45:22 — “I am God, and there is no other.”

The term therefore contributes to the Old Testament's vocabulary for deity.

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4. *Elohim*: God as Divine Sovereign and Creator

The Hebrew term ʾ**ĕlōhîm (אֱלֹהִים)** is one of the most frequent designations for God in the Hebrew Bible.

Genesis 1:1 states:

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

The Hebrew text uses *ʾĕlōhîm*.

One significant feature is that *ʾĕlōhîm* is morphologically plural in form, while when referring to Israel's God it frequently takes singular verbal agreement.

The term therefore cannot simply be translated mechanically as “gods” in every occurrence.

In Genesis 1, *ʾĕlōhîm* is the Creator.

This establishes an important theological association:

Elohim → God → Creator and sovereign.

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5. YHWH: The Divine Name

The most distinctive name for Israel's God is:

יהוה — YHWH

This is conventionally represented in English Bibles as **LORD**, often in capital letters.

The name appears throughout the Hebrew Bible.

Exodus 3 provides the foundational narrative in which God reveals His name to Moses. The divine name becomes closely associated with Israel's covenant relationship with God.

Isaiah 45:5 is particularly important:

“I am YHWH, and there is no other; besides me there is no God.”

The Hebrew construction places **YHWH** and **God** in direct relationship.

The verse therefore illustrates an essential biblical distinction:

YHWH is the name/designation of Israel's God; “God” identifies the divine reality.

They are not two separate beings.

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6. *Adon* and *Adonai*: Lord and Master

The Hebrew term ʾ**ādôn (אָדוֹן)** means “lord,” “master,” or “ruler.”

It can refer to human masters or rulers.

The form ʾ**ădōnāy (אֲדֹנָי)** is frequently used in reference to God and is translated “Lord.”

This creates an important distinction between terminology:

Hebrew	Basic sense
ʾēl	God/deity
ʾĕlōhîm	God
YHWH	Divine covenant name
ʾādôn	Lord/master
ʾădōnāy	Lord

Therefore, “Lord” is not automatically equivalent to “YHWH” in every Hebrew occurrence.

Context remains essential.

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7. The Septuagint and the Development of *Kyrios*

The Septuagint, commonly abbreviated **LXX**, is the ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures.

A crucial development occurred in the Greek representation of the divine name.

The Hebrew **YHWH** was commonly represented in Greek biblical tradition by:

κύριος — kyrios

meaning:

Lord

This development is fundamental for New Testament Christology.

When a first-century Jewish Christian heard the Greek word *kyrios* in a scriptural quotation, its meaning could extend beyond the ordinary sense of “master” or “sir.”

It could represent the divine Lord of Israel.

Modern scholarship continues to debate the precise history of how and when *kyrios* came to function as the representation of the Tetragrammaton in Greek manuscripts, but there is substantial evidence for its use in this role. The relationship between YHWH and *kyrios* is particularly important when examining New Testament quotations of the Old Testament.

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8. *Theos* in the New Testament

The principal Greek word for “God” is:

θεός — theos

The word can refer to God in the singular and is the ordinary New Testament term for God.

For example:

“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”

— John 1:1

The passage uses **theos** in both clauses, although the grammatical constructions differ.

The second clause identifies the Word with divine reality while maintaining distinction between the Word and “God” with whom the Word was.

This becomes foundational for later Christian reflection on the relationship between the Father and the Son.

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9. *Kyrios* in the New Testament

The Greek term **kyrios (κύριος)** has a broad semantic range.

Depending on context it can mean:

- lord;
- master;
- owner;
- ruler;
- sir;
- the Lord.

Consequently, every occurrence of *kyrios* should not automatically be interpreted as a divine title.

Nevertheless, its significance changes when it appears in Old Testament quotations or theological contexts.

This is particularly evident in passages where New Testament writers apply Old Testament language concerning YHWH to Jesus.

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10. Deuteronomy 6:4 and the Shema

One of the foundational statements of Israel's faith is the **Shema**:

“Hear, O Israel: YHWH our God, YHWH is one.”

— Deuteronomy 6:4

In the Greek Septuagint, the verse uses **kyrios**:

“The Lord is our God, the Lord is one.”

The Shema therefore forms part of the conceptual background for New Testament discussions of God and Jesus.

This is especially important in **1 Corinthians 8:6**.

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11. 1 Corinthians 8:6 — One God and One Lord

Paul writes:

“Yet for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things and through whom we exist.”

This verse is one of the most important texts for understanding the relationship between “God” and “Lord.”

Paul says:

One God — the Father

and

One Lord — Jesus Christ

At first reading, someone might conclude that Paul is placing the Father in the category “God” and Jesus in a separate, lesser category called “Lord.”

However, the surrounding language complicates such a conclusion.

Paul says that:

“all things” are through Jesus Christ.

The verse therefore assigns Jesus a role in relation to creation.

Scholars have observed that Paul's formulation appears to reshape the language of Jewish monotheism around both the Father and Christ. One recent scholarly analysis specifically argues that Paul's use of *kyrios* in 1 Corinthians 8:6 is connected to the Shema and places Christ within the divine identity while simultaneously distinguishing Him from the Father.

This distinction is crucial:

Jesus is distinguished from the Father without being excluded from the divine sphere.

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12. Psalm 110:1 — “The LORD said to my Lord”

Psalm 110:1 states:

“The LORD says to my Lord: ‘Sit at my right hand...’”

The Hebrew text distinguishes between:

YHWH

and

my lord

The Psalm became one of the most frequently used Old Testament texts in early Christian interpretation.

Jesus refers to this passage in the Synoptic Gospels.

The question concerns the identity and status of the Messiah:

If David calls the Messiah “Lord,” how is the Messiah merely David's son?

The Psalm therefore became significant for early Christian claims concerning Jesus' exaltation.

The New Testament repeatedly interprets Jesus through Psalm 110.

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13. Isaiah 45:23 and Philippians 2:9–11

Isaiah 45 contains one of the strongest Old Testament statements about the universal sovereignty of YHWH:

“To me every knee shall bow, every tongue shall swear allegiance.”

Isaiah's context is explicitly monotheistic.

YHWH declares that there is no other God.

Philippians 2:9–11 says that God exalted Jesus and that:

“every knee should bow”

and

“every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.”

The verbal and conceptual correspondence with Isaiah 45 is significant.

Modern scholarship continues to discuss the precise nature of the allusion, but the connection between Isaiah 45 and Philippians 2 is widely recognized as important for understanding Paul's Christology. Recent research notes that Isaiah has YHWH as the object of universal acclamation, while Philippians applies the language to the exalted Jesus under the title *kyrios*.

Thus:

Isaiah 45 → universal homage to YHWH

Philippians 2 → universal homage to Jesus as Lord

This does not erase the distinction between the Father and Son. Rather, it demonstrates the extraordinary status assigned to Jesus within Paul's monotheistic framework.

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14. Joel 2:32 and Romans 10:13

Joel 2:32 states:

“Everyone who calls on the name of YHWH shall be saved.”

The Hebrew text explicitly uses **YHWH**.

Paul quotes this statement in Romans 10:13:

“Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.”

The surrounding passage is concerned with confessing Jesus as Lord.

Romans 10:9 says:

“If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

The sequence is remarkable:

Joel: Call upon the name of YHWH.

Romans: Call upon the name of the Lord in the context of Jesus.

This provides one of the strongest examples of Old Testament language about Israel's God being incorporated into New Testament proclamation about Jesus.

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15. Philippians 2:6–11

Philippians 2:6–11 is one of the most important Christological passages in the New Testament.

The passage describes Jesus as existing in the **“form of God”**, followed by His self-emptying, incarnation, obedience, death, and subsequent exaltation.

The climax occurs in verse 11:

“Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.”

The passage therefore maintains two realities:

1. Jesus is distinct from the Father.
2. Jesus receives universal acknowledgment as Lord.

The climax is not merely that Jesus receives authority from God. The language also echoes the universal homage due to YHWH in Isaiah 45.

Scholarly analysis of Philippians 2 has therefore frequently treated the passage as a central witness to early Christian high Christology.

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16. John 1:1 — The Word and God

The Gospel of John begins:

“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”

Three observations are important.

First

The Word already exists “in the beginning.”

Second

The Word is **with God**, indicating distinction.

Third

The Word **was God**, indicating participation in divine identity.

John then states:

“And the Word became flesh.”

This connects the eternal Word with the historical Jesus.

John therefore provides an important framework for understanding how Jesus can be distinguished from the Father while simultaneously being described in divine terms.

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17. John 20:28 — “My Lord and My God”

Following Jesus' resurrection, Thomas responds:

“My Lord and my God!”

The Greek expression is:

ὁ κύριός μου καὶ ὁ θεός μου

ho kyrios mou kai ho theos mou

Literally:

“My Lord and my God.”

Two titles occur together:

Kyrios — Lord

Theos — God

Both are directly applied to the risen Jesus.

This is particularly significant because it demonstrates that the New Testament does not reserve the term *theos* exclusively for the Father.

Jesus can be addressed as:

Lord

and

God.

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18. Is “Lord” Always Equivalent to “God”?

No.

This qualification is essential for responsible biblical interpretation.

The word **kyrios** can be used of:

- human masters;
- landowners;
- rulers;
- respected persons;
- Jesus;
- God.

Therefore:

Every “Lord” in the New Testament does not automatically mean “God.”

The argument must be based on context.

For example, when someone addresses Jesus as “Lord” in an ordinary social interaction, *kyrios* may simply mean “sir” or “master.”

But when *kyrios* occurs in:

- Old Testament quotations concerning YHWH;
- universal worship contexts;
- salvation formulas;
- eschatological judgment;
- creation theology;
- divine sovereignty passages;

the theological significance can be substantially greater.

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19. Is “God” Always Equivalent to “the Father”?

Again, not necessarily.

The New Testament frequently uses “God” in a way that refers specifically to the Father, especially when distinguishing the Father from Jesus.

For example:

“one God, the Father... and one Lord, Jesus Christ”

— 1 Corinthians 8:6.

But this does not mean the word **theos** can never be applied to Jesus.

John 1:1 and John 20:28 demonstrate otherwise.

Thus we should distinguish:

“God” as a designation of the Father in a particular context

from

“God” as a designation of deity.

The same distinction is necessary for “Lord.”

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20. Identity and Relationship

The New Testament's language concerning God and Jesus can therefore be summarized in two dimensions.

Identity

Jesus is described using divine language.

Relationship

Jesus is distinguished from the Father.

This combination is one of the central features of New Testament Christology.

The New Testament does not simply say:

Jesus = the Father.

Nor does it simply say:

Jesus = a created being who is merely God's representative.

Instead, texts such as John 1, 1 Corinthians 8, Philippians 2, and John 20 maintain both **distinction** and **divine status**.

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21. “Jesus Is Lord” as an Early Christian Confession

The confession **“Jesus is Lord”** appears to have been central to early Christian identity.

Romans 10:9 connects confession of Jesus as Lord with belief in His resurrection.

1 Corinthians 12:3 declares:

“Jesus is Lord.”

Philippians 2:11 declares:

“Jesus Christ is Lord.”

The confession therefore involves more than respect for Jesus.

It expresses allegiance to Jesus as the risen Messiah and sovereign Lord.

Scholarly studies of early Christology have identified the title *Kyrios* as one of the major categories through which early Christians expressed their understanding of Jesus.

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22. Lordship and Worship

Another important issue is worship.

The New Testament presents Jesus as receiving extraordinary honor.

Philippians 2:10 speaks of every knee bowing before Jesus.

Revelation repeatedly portrays Jesus in heavenly worship scenes.

The significance becomes particularly strong when read against Jewish monotheism.

If worship belongs uniquely to the God of Israel, the inclusion of Jesus within heavenly worship requires explanation.

This is one reason modern scholars have devoted substantial attention to the phenomenon sometimes described as **early Christian "high Christology."**

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23. The Old Testament Background Is Essential

The New Testament's description of Jesus cannot be fully understood in isolation from the Old Testament.

The theological background includes:

- YHWH as Creator;
- YHWH as Israel's covenant God;
- YHWH as the only God;
- YHWH as universal King;
- YHWH as judge;
- YHWH as Savior;
- YHWH as the one whose name is invoked for salvation;
- YHWH as the recipient of universal homage.

When comparable roles and scriptural language are applied to Jesus, the significance is much greater than the simple use of a title.

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24. The Difference Between "God" and "Lord"

The following distinction is useful, provided it is not treated as absolute.

Category	"God"	"Lord"
Hebrew	*El, Elohim*	*Adon, Adonai*
Divine name	YHWH	Often represented by "LORD"
Greek	*Theos*	*Kyrios*
Primary emphasis	Deity	Authority/Lordship
Can refer to humans?	Sometimes "gods" in certain contexts	Yes
Applied to Jesus?	Yes	Yes
Applied to Father?	Yes	Yes
Automatically identical in every occurrence?	No	No

The key conclusion is therefore:

"God" and "Lord" are overlapping but not identical lexical categories.

"God" primarily concerns deity.

"Lord" primarily concerns lordship, authority, sovereignty, and mastery.

Yet in biblical theology, divine lordship and divine identity can overlap.

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25. Jesus Christ: Lord and God

The cumulative evidence can now be stated carefully.

Jesus is called Lord

Examples:

- Romans 10:9
- 1 Corinthians 12:3
- Philippians 2:11
- Luke 2:11

- Acts 2:36

Jesus is described in divine terms

Examples:

- John 1:1
- John 1:14
- John 20:28
- Philippians 2:6
- Colossians 1:15–20
- Hebrews 1:1–12
- Titus 2:13, depending on grammatical interpretation

Jesus participates in divine functions

The New Testament associates Jesus with:

- creation;
- salvation;
- judgment;
- forgiveness;
- universal authority;
- resurrection;
- worship.

This cumulative picture is more significant than any single word.

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26. Major Interpretive Question: Does Paul Make Jesus Equal to YHWH?

This question deserves careful treatment.

There are several levels of argument.

Weak argument

“Jesus is called *kyrios*, therefore every use of *kyrios* means YHWH.”

This is linguistically inadequate.

Stronger argument

Certain New Testament passages place Jesus within contexts where Old Testament statements about YHWH are applied to Him.

Examples include:

- Joel 2:32 → Romans 10:13
- Isaiah 45:23 → Philippians 2:10–11
- Psalm 102 → Hebrews 1:10–12
- Isaiah 40:3 → Gospel traditions concerning Jesus and John the Baptist

These passages require contextual analysis.

The scholarly literature contains different explanations for the precise nature of these allusions, but the evidence clearly demonstrates that early Christians interpreted Jesus through Israel's Scriptures in ways that went beyond assigning Him an ordinary human title.

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27. Distinction Without Separation

One of the most useful formulations for understanding the New Testament is:

Distinction does not necessarily mean separation of divine identity.

The Father and Son are distinguished.

Jesus prays to the Father.

The Father sends the Son.

The Son returns to the Father.

The Son is exalted by the Father.

Yet Jesus is also described using divine language and receives universal homage.

This combination eventually became foundational to Trinitarian theology.

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28. From New Testament Evidence to Later Trinitarian Theology

The word study itself does not constitute the entire doctrine of the Trinity.

The formal theological language of:

one essence/substance

and

three persons

developed through later Christian reflection.

However, the conceptual problem that Trinitarian theology sought to address is already present in the New Testament:

1. God is one.
2. The Father is God.
3. Jesus is distinguished from the Father.
4. Jesus is described in divine terms.
5. The Holy Spirit is also associated with God and divine activity.

Later Christian theology attempted to formulate a coherent explanation of these biblical claims.

Therefore, the doctrine of the Trinity should not be confused with a simple lexical definition of “God” and “Lord.”

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29. Conclusion

The biblical distinction between **God** and **Lord** becomes clearer when the original Hebrew and Greek vocabulary is examined.

The Old Testament uses terms such as:

ʾēl
ʾĕlōhîm
YHWH
ʾādôn / ʾădōnāy

The New Testament uses:

theos
kyrios

The terms do not function as rigid technical categories in which “God” always means the Father and “Lord” always means Jesus.

Rather, they operate within a complex biblical vocabulary of deity, identity, authority, sovereignty, and covenant.

The most important observation is the development of **kyrios**.

Because the Greek Scriptures frequently use *kyrios* in connection with YHWH, the New Testament's repeated confession that **Jesus is Kyrios** becomes theologically significant when accompanied by Old Testament quotations and allusions.

The evidence is particularly striking in:

- **1 Corinthians 8:6**, where Jesus is the one Lord through whom all things exist;
- **Romans 10:9–13**, where confession of Jesus as Lord is connected with Joel's language about calling on the name of YHWH;
- **Philippians 2:9–11**, where Jesus receives universal homage in language strongly echoing Isaiah 45;
- **John 1:1–14**, where the Word is both with God and is God before becoming flesh;
- **John 20:28**, where the risen Jesus is addressed directly as “My Lord and my God.”

Therefore, the statement:

“Jesus Christ is Lord”

cannot be reduced to the idea that Jesus is merely a respected teacher, human master, or subordinate ruler.

Within the New Testament's Jewish scriptural framework, **Jesus' lordship is connected to divine sovereignty and, in significant passages, to the identity and prerogatives of the God of Israel.**

At the same time, the New Testament maintains a distinction between Jesus and the Father.

Thus the central biblical tension can be expressed as:

One God — yet Father and Son are distinct.
Jesus is Lord — yet the Father is also Lord.
Jesus is described as God — yet Jesus is not the Father.

This combination of **monotheism, distinction, divine status, and universal lordship** provides the essential foundation for the later Christian doctrine of the Trinity.

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For the relationship between the Shema, *kyrios*, and Paul's formulation in 1 Corinthians 8:6, see recent discussion in *New Testament Studies*.

Final Thesis

The evidence of the Old and New Testaments supports the following formulation:

“God” and “Lord” are not two names for two different divine beings. “God” (*Elohim/Theos*) primarily identifies deity, while “Lord” (*Adonai/Kyrios*) expresses lordship, authority, and sovereignty. Yet because *Kyrios* functions in the Greek Scriptures as a designation associated with YHWH, the New Testament's application of *Kyrios* to Jesus carries profound theological significance. Jesus is distinguished from the Father, yet He is confessed as Lord, described in divine terms, associated with creation and salvation, and included in the universal homage due to God. Thus the confession “Jesus Christ is Lord” stands at the heart of New Testament Christology and is inseparable from the biblical confession of one God.”

Research Paper

The LORD Is Our God, God Is Spirit, and Jesus Christ Is God

A Biblical-Theological Study of YHWH, Elohim, Adonai, the Divine Spirit, and the Incarnation

Abstract

The biblical confession that **“the LORD is our God”**, the declaration that **“God is spirit,”** and the New Testament confession of **Jesus Christ as Lord and God** are deeply interconnected themes. This paper examines these themes through the Hebrew terms *Elohim*, *YHWH*, and *Adonai*, and the Greek terms *Theos* and *Kyrios*. It argues that the biblical distinction between these words should not obscure their theological relationship: **YHWH is identified as Elohim, the LORD is God, and divine lordship belongs to the one God.** The New Testament then makes the extraordinary claim that Jesus Christ is *Kyrios* and explicitly associates Him with

Theos. John describes the eternal Word as God and declares that the Word became flesh; Paul states that the fullness of deity dwells bodily in Christ; and Thomas addresses the risen Jesus as “My Lord and my God.” The paper concludes that the Incarnation is central to Christian theology: the eternal divine Word became flesh in Jesus Christ, while the New Testament maintains a distinction between the Son and the Father.

Keywords: YHWH, Elohim, Adonai, God, Lord, Spirit, Jesus Christ, Incarnation, Theos, Kyrios, Christology, Trinity

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1. Introduction

One of the central declarations of biblical faith is:

“Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one.”
— Deuteronomy 6:4

This confession stands at the heart of Israel's faith.

The Hebrew expression contains two especially important terms:

YHWH — the divine name represented in many English translations as **LORD**

Elohim — **God**

The Bible therefore establishes a fundamental relationship:

YHWH is Elohim.

The Old Testament also speaks of God as **Lord**, using the Hebrew term *Adonai* and related forms.

The New Testament introduces the Greek terms:

Theos — God

Kyrios — Lord

And then it makes a remarkable confession:

Jesus Christ is Lord.

At the same time, Jesus is described in divine terms. John writes:

“The Word was God.” — John 1:1

and then:

“The Word became flesh.” — John 1:14

Paul states:

“In him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily.” — Colossians 2:9.

Thomas finally addresses the risen Christ:

“My Lord and my God!” — John 20:28

These texts create a profound theological question:

How does the New Testament understand Jesus Christ as Lord and God within the biblical confession of one God who is Spirit?

This paper investigates that question.

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2. God Is Spirit

The starting point of this study must be Jesus' statement in John 4:24:

“God is spirit.”

The Greek expression is:

πνεῦμα ὁ θεός — pneuma ho theos

The statement describes God's nature in relation to worship. Jesus teaches that true worship cannot be reduced to a particular geographical location or merely external religious form. God is Spirit, and therefore worship must be “in spirit and truth.”

This gives us the first theological proposition:

God is Spirit.

God is not a material object contained within creation. Scripture consistently presents Him as invisible, eternal, and transcendent.

Paul describes God as the One who is immortal and invisible (1 Timothy 1:17; 6:16).

Thus, biblical theology begins not with God as a physical being but with God as the **living divine Spirit**.

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3. The Hebrew Concept of Elohim

The principal Hebrew word translated **God** is:

אֱלֹהִים — Elohim

It occurs extensively throughout the Old Testament.

Genesis 1:1 begins:

“In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.”

The God who creates the universe is *Elohim*.

Thus *Elohim* is associated with:

- deity;
- creation;
- sovereignty;
- judgment;
- divine power;
- covenant activity.

The word itself, however, should not simply be treated as another personal name for God.

A useful distinction is:

Elohim identifies God as God.

YHWH identifies the covenant God by His distinctive divine name.

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4. YHWH: The Divine Name

The Hebrew name:

יהוה — YHWH

is conventionally represented in English Bibles by **LORD**, especially in capital letters.

YHWH is the distinctive covenant name associated with Israel's God.

Deuteronomy 4:35 provides an exceptionally important statement:

“YHWH is God; there is no other besides him.”

The Hebrew construction identifies YHWH with *Elohim*.

Thus:

YHWH is Elohim.

This is one of the strongest biblical foundations for understanding the relationship between the terms.

They are not two separate divine beings.

Rather, Scripture identifies **YHWH as the one God**.

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5. YHWH and Adonai

Another important Hebrew designation is:

אֲדֹנָי — Adonai

meaning **Lord**.

The underlying concept includes:

- lordship;
- mastery;
- authority;
- sovereignty.

Consequently, the Old Testament can speak of the God of Israel as:

YHWH

and

Adonai

The terms are not lexically identical.

Nevertheless, they can refer to the same divine Lord.

This allows us to formulate the relationship:

YHWH is God.

YHWH is Lord.

God is Lord.

The words emphasize different aspects of the biblical understanding of God.

---

6. “The LORD Our God”

The Shema of Deuteronomy 6:4 is therefore particularly significant:

“Hear, O Israel: YHWH our Elohim, YHWH is one.”

The phrase brings together:

YHWH — divine name

Elohim — God

one — divine unity

The expression **“the LORD our God”** therefore has both theological and covenantal significance.

Israel does not merely confess that a God exists.

Israel confesses:

YHWH is our God.

The God who created the universe is also the God who enters covenant relationship with His people.

---

7. God and Lord: Distinction Without Separation

A common mistake is to treat “God” and “Lord” as if they represented two different levels of deity.

For example:

God = Father
Lord = Jesus

Such a formula is inadequate because the New Testament applies both concepts more broadly.

The Father is God.

Jesus is called Lord.

Jesus is also described as God.

The Father is also Lord.

Therefore:

“God” and “Lord” are not mutually exclusive categories.

“God” primarily emphasizes **divinity**.

“Lord” primarily emphasizes **authority, sovereignty, and mastery**.

The same divine reality can therefore be described using both concepts.

---

8. The Greek Term Theos

The principal Greek term for God is:

θεός — Theos

The New Testament uses *Theos* extensively for the God of Israel.

But the New Testament also applies divine language to Christ.

John 1:1 states:

“The Word was God.”

The passage simultaneously says:

“The Word was with God.”

This creates two truths:

1. The Word is distinguished from God with whom He is.
2. The Word is described as God.

This distinction is fundamental to Christian Christology.

---

9. The Word Was God

John 1:1 is one of the foundational Christological texts of the New Testament.

The passage begins:

“In the beginning was the Word.”

This deliberately echoes Genesis 1:1:

“In the beginning...”

The Word therefore exists before creation.

John then says:

“The Word was with God.”

The Word is personally distinguishable from the Father.

Then:

“The Word was God.”

The Word participates in divine identity.

John 1:3 adds:

“All things were made through him.”

Thus the Word is associated with creation itself.

---

10. The Word Became Flesh

The climax of John's opening section is:

“And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us.”
— John 1:14

This is the doctrine of the **Incarnation**.

The Word did not merely speak through a human prophet.

The Word **became flesh**.

Christian theology therefore confesses:

The eternal Word became truly human in Jesus Christ.

The Incarnation does not mean that God ceased to be divine.

It means that the divine Word entered human existence.

---

11. Jesus Christ Is Lord

The New Testament repeatedly calls Jesus:

Kyrios — Lord

Paul declares:

“Jesus Christ is Lord.”
— Philippians 2:11

Romans 10:9 says:

“If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved.”

This confession is significant because *Kyrios* is not merely an ordinary title of respect.

The Greek term can mean “lord,” “master,” or “ruler,” but in biblical contexts it can also function as a designation of the divine Lord. Scholarly discussion of the Greek Scriptures notes the important relationship between *Kyrios* and the Hebrew divine name YHWH.

Therefore, the confession:

Jesus is Lord

must be interpreted within the Old Testament background of divine lordship.

---

12. Jesus Christ Is God

The New Testament does not merely call Jesus Lord.

It also presents Him in explicitly divine terms.

John 1:1:

“The Word was God.”

John 20:28:

“My Lord and my God!”

Colossians 2:9:

“In him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily.”

These statements form a powerful cumulative witness.

Jesus is not described as possessing only a small portion of divine qualities.

Paul speaks of the **fullness of deity** dwelling bodily in Christ.

---

13. “My Lord and My God”

John 20:28 is particularly important.

After encountering the risen Jesus, Thomas says:

“My Lord and my God!”

The Greek is:

ὁ κύριός μου καὶ ὁ θεός μου

ho Kyrios mou kai ho Theos mou

Literally:

“My Lord and my God.”

The two terms appear together:

Kyrios — Lord

Theos — God

And they are addressed to the risen Jesus.

This provides one of the clearest New Testament examples of Jesus being confessed as both Lord and God.

---

14. The Fullness of Deity in Christ

Colossians 2:9 deserves special attention:

“For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily.”

Three ideas are brought together:

Fullness

Nothing essential to deity is lacking.

Deity

Paul speaks of divine nature, not merely divine qualities.

Bodily

The divine fullness is associated with Christ's embodied existence.

This provides an exceptionally concise expression of Christian Incarnation theology.

Jesus Christ is not merely a spiritual revelation without real humanity.

The divine is present **bodily** in Christ.

---

15. Jesus as the Image of the Invisible God

Colossians 1:15 describes Christ as:

“the image of the invisible God.”

This connects directly with the biblical teaching that God is invisible and Spirit.

The theological pattern is:

God is invisible.

Christ is the image of the invisible God.

The Word became flesh.

Therefore, Christ is the visible revelation of the invisible God.

This does not mean that Jesus is simply the Father.

The New Testament maintains distinction between Father and Son.

Rather:

The Son reveals the Father.

---

16. The Incarnation Is Not Mere Appearance

The New Testament insists on the reality of Christ's humanity.

1 John 4:2 speaks of confessing:

“Jesus Christ has come in the flesh.”

John 1:14 says:

“The Word became flesh.”

Colossians 2:9 says:

“The fullness of deity dwells bodily.”

The biblical doctrine is therefore neither:

Jesus was only God pretending to be human,

nor:

Jesus was only a human being representing God.

Instead, Christian theology understands the Incarnation as the union of true humanity and divine identity in Jesus Christ.

---

17. YHWH, Elohim, Adonai, Theos, and Kyrios

The biblical vocabulary can now be organized as follows:

Term	Language	Primary significance
Elohim	Hebrew	God / deity
YHWH	Hebrew	Divine covenant name
Adonai	Hebrew	Lord / sovereign
Theos	Greek	God / deity

Kyrios	Greek	Lord / master / sovereign
Jesus Christ	New Testament	Messiah, Son, Lord, divine Word

The words should not be treated as exact lexical synonyms.

But they participate in a larger theological framework concerning the identity and sovereignty of the one God.

---

18. The LORD and Kyrios

The Septuagint is particularly important here.

Greek translators frequently rendered YHWH with:

Kyrios — Lord.

Scholarly research on the Septuagint's rendering of the divine name identifies *Kyrios* as an important Greek equivalent for YHWH.

This provides an important background to the New Testament's confession:

Jesus is Kyrios.

The significance is especially strong when New Testament authors apply Old Testament passages about YHWH to Jesus.

---

19. Isaiah 45 and Philippians 2

Isaiah 45 contains a powerful declaration of YHWH's universal sovereignty:

“To me every knee shall bow, every tongue shall swear allegiance.”

Philippians 2:10–11 says concerning Jesus:

“Every knee should bow... and every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.”

The correspondence is significant.

The Old Testament describes universal acknowledgment of YHWH.

Paul describes universal acknowledgment of Jesus as Lord.

The result is not the creation of a second God.

Rather, Jesus' lordship is expressed within the framework of biblical monotheism.

---

20. Joel 2:32 and Romans 10:13

Joel declares:

“Everyone who calls on the name of YHWH shall be saved.”

Romans 10:13 quotes the passage:

“Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.”

The immediate context of Romans 10 concerns Jesus.

This provides another important connection between:

YHWH

Lord

Jesus

salvation

The New Testament therefore uses Old Testament language concerning the Lord of Israel in its proclamation of Jesus.

---

21. One God and One Lord

1 Corinthians 8:6 says:

“For us there is one God, the Father... and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things.”

This is a crucial text.

Paul distinguishes:

the Father

and

Jesus Christ.

But he also associates Jesus with the existence of **all things**.

This means that New Testament Christology cannot simply be reduced to:

Father = God

and

Jesus = merely a human Lord.

The wider New Testament testimony must be considered.

---

22. The Divine Spirit and Jesus Christ

We can now bring the major themes together.

God is Spirit

John 4:24.

YHWH is God

Deuteronomy 4:35.

The Word was God

John 1:1.

The Word became flesh

John 1:14.

Jesus is Lord

Philippians 2:11.

Jesus is addressed as God

John 20:28.

Fullness of deity dwells bodily in Christ

Colossians 2:9.

Together these statements establish the theological movement:

The God who is Spirit is revealed through the eternal Word, and the Word became flesh in Jesus Christ.

---

23. “God in Flesh”: A Careful Formulation

The phrase **“Jesus Christ is God in flesh”** is a concise Christian theological formulation.

For academic precision, it can be expanded:

Jesus Christ is the eternal divine Word who became flesh and truly entered human existence while remaining divine.

This formulation avoids a possible misunderstanding.

It does not mean:

Jesus is the Father.

Rather:

Jesus is the divine Son/Word who is distinct from the Father.

John 1:1 itself gives the pattern:

with God

and

was God.

Distinction and divine identity are both present.

---

24. God Is Spirit, Yet the Word Became Flesh

This may appear paradoxical.

If God is Spirit, how can God become flesh?

The answer supplied by Christian theology is the Incarnation.

The eternal Word did not cease to be divine.

Instead, He assumed human nature.

Thus:

Divinity was not transformed into humanity.

Rather:

The divine Word assumed humanity.

This distinction is fundamental to orthodox Christian Christology.

---

25. Lordship and Divinity

The title **Lord** therefore has two dimensions when applied to Jesus.

Messianic Lordship

Jesus is the promised Messiah and King.

Divine Lordship

In important New Testament passages, His lordship is expressed through Old Testament language associated with YHWH.

Consequently, the confession:

“Jesus Christ is Lord”

is much more profound than saying:

“Jesus is a respected teacher.”

It is a confession of allegiance to the risen Christ as sovereign Lord.

---

26. Theological Synthesis

The biblical data can be summarized in a sequence:

Old Testament

YHWH is Elohim.

YHWH is Lord.

God is one.

New Testament

God is Spirit.

The Word was God.

The Word became flesh.

Jesus is Lord.

Jesus is called God.

The fullness of deity dwells bodily in Christ.

The Christian doctrine of the Incarnation arises from bringing these claims together.

---

27. A Note on the Trinity

The word **Trinity** does not appear in the biblical text.

Nevertheless, later Trinitarian theology developed as an attempt to explain several biblical affirmations simultaneously:

1. There is one God.
2. The Father is God.
3. The Son is divine.
4. The Holy Spirit is divine.
5. The Father and Son are distinct.
6. The Son and Spirit are distinct.

The present study is not attempting to derive the entire later doctrine of the Trinity from the words *Elohim*, *YHWH*, and *Adonai* alone.

Rather, it demonstrates the biblical foundation upon which Christian Trinitarian Christology developed.

---

28. Central Thesis

The central thesis of this study can be stated as follows:

The Old Testament identifies YHWH as Elohim and presents Him as the sovereign Lord. The New Testament describes God as Spirit, identifies the eternal Word as God, declares that the Word became flesh, and repeatedly confesses Jesus Christ as Lord. It further applies divine language directly to Jesus, most explicitly in the confession "My Lord and my God" and in the declaration that the fullness of deity dwells bodily in Christ. Therefore, within the framework of Christian biblical theology, Jesus Christ is understood as the eternal divine Word who became flesh—the Lord and God revealed in human existence—while remaining personally distinct from the Father.

---

29. Conclusion

The biblical phrase:

"The LORD our God"

contains a profound theology of divine identity.

YHWH is the covenant name of Israel's God.

Elohim identifies Him as God.

Adonai expresses His lordship.

The New Testament uses:

Theos for God.

Kyrios for Lord.

And the New Testament makes the extraordinary confession:

Jesus Christ is Lord.

John takes the argument deeper:

“The Word was God.”

Then:

“The Word became flesh.”

Paul gives another concise expression:

“In him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily.”

And Thomas responds to the risen Jesus:

“My Lord and my God!”

The central Christian claim is therefore not merely that Jesus represents God.

It is that the **eternal divine Word became flesh in Jesus Christ**.

God is Spirit.

The LORD is God.

The Lord is divine.

The Word is God.

The Word became flesh.

Jesus Christ is Lord.

Jesus Christ is confessed as God.

Therefore, the mystery at the heart of Christian faith is the **Incarnation**:

The invisible God is revealed through the incarnate Son; the eternal Word became flesh, and Jesus Christ is confessed as Lord and God.

“My Lord and my God!” — John 20:28

Selected Primary Biblical Texts

- Genesis 1:1–3
- Exodus 3:13–15
- Deuteronomy 4:35
- Deuteronomy 6:4
- Psalm 110:1
- Isaiah 45:5, 23
- Joel 2:32
- John 1:1–18
- John 4:24
- John 14:9
- John 20:28
- Romans 10:9–13
- 1 Corinthians 8:4–6
- Philippians 2:6–11
- Colossians 1:15–20
- Colossians 2:9
- Hebrews 1:1–12
- 1 John 4:2

Selected Research Sources

The relationship between *YHWH* and the Greek *Kyrios* has been studied extensively in Septuagint scholarship; research specifically identifies *Kyrios* as an important Greek representation of the divine name.

The title *Kyrios* also became a major designation for Jesus in early Christianity and can carry the meaning of sovereign Lord in New Testament contexts.

John 4:24 provides the explicit New Testament statement that **God is Spirit**, while John 1 and Colossians 2:9 provide key texts for the relationship between divine identity and the Incarnation.

[Blog Version]

God Is Spirit, and Jesus Christ Is God Manifested in Flesh

A Biblical Study of God, the Lord, and the Incarnation of Jesus Christ

The Bible presents a profound truth about the nature of God:

“God is spirit.”
— John 4:24

This statement provides an important foundation for understanding the relationship between **God, the Lord, and Jesus Christ**.

The Bible also declares that Jesus Christ is **Lord**, and the New Testament describes Him in unmistakably divine terms. John says that the eternal Word was God and then declares that:

“The Word became flesh.”
— John 1:14

Therefore, Christian faith makes a remarkable confession:

The eternal divine Word became flesh in Jesus Christ.

Jesus Christ is not merely a human being who received the title “Lord.” The New Testament presents Him as the divine Son who entered human existence.

---

1. God Is Spirit

Jesus gives one of the clearest statements about God's nature:

“God is spirit, and those who worship him must worship in spirit and truth.”
— John 4:24

The statement is profound.

Jesus does not merely say:

“God has a spirit.”

He says:

“God is spirit.”

Spirit describes the nature of God.

God is not limited to a physical body or confined to a particular geographical location.

The God revealed in Scripture is transcendent, invisible, eternal, and spiritual.

Paul similarly describes God as:

“the King of the ages, immortal, invisible, the only God.”
— 1 Timothy 1:17

And 1 Timothy 6:16 speaks of God as the One:

“whom no one has ever seen or can see.”

The biblical picture is therefore clear:

God is Spirit.

---

2. The LORD Is God

The Old Testament repeatedly identifies **YHWH** as God.

Deuteronomy 4:35 says:

“YHWH is God; there is no other besides him.”

The Hebrew expression is:

YHWH hu ha-Elohim

“YHWH, He is God.”

This connects two important biblical concepts:

YHWH — the divine name

Elohim — God

Therefore:

YHWH is Elohim.

The LORD is God.

The Old Testament does not present YHWH and Elohim as two separate gods.

Rather, different terms are used to speak about the one God.

---

3. The LORD Is Lord

The Hebrew Scriptures also speak of God as **Lord**.

The word **Adonai** expresses lordship, authority, and sovereignty.

Thus, when we speak of:

“the LORD our God”

we are bringing together God's identity and His sovereignty.

The biblical pattern can therefore be expressed:

YHWH is Elohim.

YHWH is Lord.

Elohim is Lord.

These statements are not identifying three gods.

They describe the one God from different perspectives.

---

4. God Is Spirit, Yet God Reveals Himself

If God is Spirit, how can human beings know Him?

The Bible's answer is **revelation**.

God reveals Himself through:

- creation;
- His covenant;
- His spoken Word;
- the prophets;
- His mighty acts;
- and ultimately through Jesus Christ.

Hebrews 1:1–2 says that God spoke through the prophets and has spoken decisively through His Son.

The New Testament therefore presents Jesus as the supreme revelation of God.

---

5. The Eternal Word Was God

John's Gospel begins with a remarkable statement:

“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”
— John 1:1

Three truths are presented.

The Word existed in the beginning.

The Word did not begin at Bethlehem.

The Word was with God.

There is a distinction between the Word and God the Father.

The Word was God.

The Word possesses divine identity.

John therefore presents both **distinction** and **divinity**.

---

6. The Word Became Flesh

Then comes one of the most important statements in Scripture:

“And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us.”
— John 1:14

This is the doctrine of the **Incarnation**.

The eternal Word did not merely appear to be human.

He **became flesh**.

The divine Word entered human history.

The Christian confession is therefore:

Jesus Christ is the incarnate Word.

This is why Jesus can be described simultaneously in terms of humanity and divinity.

He experienced:

- birth;
- hunger;
- thirst;
- weariness;
- suffering;
- death.

Yet the New Testament also attributes to Him divine identity and authority.

---

7. Jesus Christ Is Lord

The early Christian confession was:

“Jesus is Lord.”

Paul writes:

“No one can say ‘Jesus is Lord’ except in the Holy Spirit.”
— 1 Corinthians 12:3

And Philippians 2:11 declares:

“Every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.”

The Greek word is:

Kyrios — κύριος

This word means “Lord,” “master,” or “sovereign.”

But its significance becomes much greater when we remember that **Kyrios** was also used in the Greek Scriptures in connection with the divine name YHWH.

Therefore, the confession:

Jesus is Lord

must be understood within the biblical story of God's sovereignty.

---

8. Jesus Christ Is God

The New Testament does not stop at calling Jesus Lord.

John 1:1 describes the Word as God.

Thomas, after seeing the resurrected Jesus, declares:

“My Lord and my God!”
— John 20:28

The Greek text is especially striking:

ho Kyrios mou kai ho Theos mou

“My Lord and my God.”

Thomas applies both titles to the risen Jesus:

Lord — Kyrios

God — Theos

This is one of the clearest confessions of Jesus' divine identity in the New Testament.

---

9. The Fullness of Deity Dwells Bodily

Colossians provides another extraordinary statement:

“For in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily.”
— Colossians 2:9

Notice the two dimensions:

Fullness of deity

and

bodily

This is precisely the mystery of the Incarnation.

Jesus is not merely a man who represents God.

Paul speaks of the **fullness of deity** dwelling in Him bodily.

Thus:

Divine fullness + human embodiment.

---

10. God Manifested in Flesh

The traditional Christian confession often uses the phrase:

“God manifested in the flesh.”

This language is associated particularly with 1 Timothy 3:16, although there is an important textual variation in the Greek manuscripts, so the verse should not be treated in isolation.

The same doctrine is strongly supported by the wider New Testament witness:

John 1:1 — the Word was God.

John 1:14 — the Word became flesh.

John 20:28 — Jesus is confessed as Lord and God.

Colossians 2:9 — the fullness of deity dwells bodily in Christ.

Philippians 2:6–11 — Christ is described in divine terms and exalted as Lord.

Together these passages provide a substantial biblical foundation for the doctrine of the Incarnation.

---

11. “God in Flesh” Does Not Mean “The Father Became the Son”

This distinction is essential.

When Christians say:

“Jesus is God manifested in flesh,”

they should not mean:

“Jesus is the Father.”

The New Testament distinguishes the Father and the Son.

Jesus prays to the Father.

The Father sends the Son.

The Son speaks of returning to the Father.

Yet Jesus is also described as divine.

Therefore the biblical position is:

Jesus is not the Father, but Jesus is truly divine.

This distinction eventually becomes central to Trinitarian theology.

---

12. Spirit and Flesh

The Incarnation creates a profound biblical relationship between **Spirit** and **flesh**.

God is Spirit.

The eternal Word is divine.

The Word becomes flesh.

Therefore:

The invisible God is revealed through the incarnate Son.

John 1:18 says:

“No one has ever seen God; the only God, who is at the Father's side, he has made him known.”

Jesus therefore becomes the definitive revelation of the Father.

---

13. “The Lord Our God”

The Old Testament confession:

“The LORD our God”

takes on additional significance in light of the New Testament.

The Old Testament says:

YHWH is Elohim.

The Greek Scriptures use:

Kyrios for YHWH.

The New Testament proclaims:

Jesus is Kyrios.

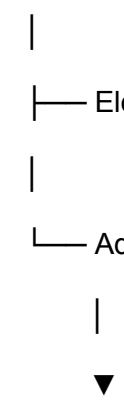
And John declares:

The Word was Theos.

Therefore the biblical vocabulary develops along this remarkable path:

OLD TESTAMENT

YHWH

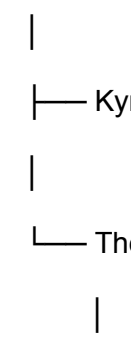


GREEK SCRIPTURES

Kyrios — Lord

NEW TESTAMENT

Jesus Christ



▼

INCARNATION

“The Word became flesh”

This does not mean that the words are simply interchangeable.

Rather, it shows how the New Testament's Christology develops within the language and theology of Israel's Scriptures.

---

14. Jesus as the Visible Revelation of the Invisible God

God is Spirit and invisible.

Yet Jesus says:

“Whoever has seen me has seen the Father.”
— John 14:9

Paul says of Christ:

“He is the image of the invisible God.”
— Colossians 1:15

This does not mean that Jesus is the Father.

Rather, Jesus perfectly reveals the Father.

The invisible God is made known through the incarnate Son.

---

15. Lordship and Divine Spirit

We should therefore be precise with the statement:

“Lord is divine Spirit.”

As a lexical statement, this is not the definition of *Adonai* or *Kyrios*.

Adonai/Kyrios means Lord, master, ruler, or sovereign.

But the **Lord who is God is Spirit**.

So the theological statement can properly be expressed:

The Lord is the divine God who is Spirit.

And when the New Testament identifies Jesus as Lord while also describing Him as divine and incarnate, Christian theology understands His lordship as belonging to His divine identity as well as His messianic kingship.

---

16. The Great Biblical Movement

The Bible presents a remarkable movement:

Creation

God creates all things.

Revelation

God reveals Himself to humanity.

Covenant

YHWH establishes covenant relationship with Israel.

Prophecy

The prophets speak of God's coming salvation and kingdom.

Incarnation

The eternal Word becomes flesh.

Cross

Jesus gives Himself for humanity.

Resurrection

Jesus rises from the dead.

Exaltation

Jesus is exalted as Lord.

Universal Confession

Every tongue ultimately confesses:

“Jesus Christ is Lord.”

This is the movement from the invisible divine reality to God's revelation in the incarnate Christ.

---

17. One God, One Lord

The Christian confession therefore contains two truths that must be held together.

First:

There is one God.

This comes from Israel's fundamental confession:

“The LORD is one.”

Second:

Jesus Christ is Lord.

This becomes a central confession of the New Testament.

Third:

Jesus is described in divine terms.

John says:

“The Word was God.”

Thomas says:

“My Lord and my God.”

Paul says:

“The whole fullness of deity dwells bodily” in Christ.

These statements form the foundation upon which Christian Christology developed.

---

18. The Central Statement

The biblical teaching can therefore be summarized:

God is Spirit.

YHWH is God.

YHWH is Lord.

The eternal Word was God.

The Word became flesh.

Jesus Christ is Lord.

Jesus Christ is confessed as God.

The fullness of deity dwells bodily in Christ.

This leads to the central Christian confession:

Jesus Christ is the divine Lord who came in the flesh.

Or, in theological language:

Jesus Christ is the eternal divine Son, the Word who was with God and was God, who became flesh and dwelt among humanity.

Conclusion

The statement **“God is divine Spirit”** is directly grounded in Jesus' words:

“God is spirit.” — John 4:24

The statement **“Jesus Christ is God in flesh”** is the theological conclusion drawn from the New Testament's combined testimony concerning the eternal Word, the Incarnation, Jesus' divine titles, His works, His worship, and His resurrection.

The biblical vocabulary gives us:

Elohim — God

YHWH — the divine name

Adonai — Lord

Theos — God

Kyrios — Lord

And the New Testament brings these themes together around Jesus Christ.

The deepest mystery is therefore not simply that God exists.

It is that:

The God who is Spirit revealed Himself through the eternal Word, and the Word became flesh in Jesus Christ.

The one whom Christians confess as **Lord** is the incarnate Christ.

And the risen Christ is addressed in the words of Thomas:

“My Lord and my God!” — John 20:28

That confession stands at the heart of Christian faith:

Jesus Christ is Lord.

The Deep Meaning of “The LORD Our God”

Elohim, YHWH, Adonai, and the Lordship of Jesus Christ

The biblical phrase **“the LORD our God”** contains a depth of meaning that can easily be missed in English translation.

When we read:

“Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one.”
— Deuteronomy 6:4

the Hebrew text brings together several profound concepts:

YHWH — the LORD
Elohim — God
Echad — one

This is not simply a statement about religious belief. It is a declaration concerning the **identity, uniqueness, sovereignty, and unity of the God of Israel**.

The deeper question is therefore:

What is the relationship between YHWH, Elohim, and Adonai—and what does this mean when the New Testament calls Jesus Christ “Lord”?

---

1. “The LORD Our God”

The Hebrew of Deuteronomy 6:4 reads:

שְׁמַע יִשְׂרָאֵל יְהוָה אֱלֹהֵינוּ יְהוָה אֶחָד

Shema Yisrael, YHWH Eloheinu, YHWH Echad.

The familiar English translation is:

“Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one.”

Three important words appear:

YHWH

The divine covenant name.

Eloheinu

“Our God,” from **Elohim**.

Echad

“One.”

The statement therefore brings together:

Name → Identity → Unity

YHWH is the God of Israel, and Israel's God is one.

---

2. YHWH Is Elohim

One of the clearest biblical statements appears in Deuteronomy 4:35:

“To you it was shown, that you might know that **YHWH is God (Elohim)**; there is no other besides him.”

The Hebrew expression is:

YHWH hu ha-Elohim

meaning essentially:

“YHWH, He is God.”

This is extremely significant.

The Bible does not present:

YHWH versus Elohim

as two separate divine beings.

Instead:

YHWH is Elohim.

YHWH is the God of Israel.

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3. Elohim Is Not the Personal Name YHWH

At the same time, we should not make the opposite mistake and say that **Elohim and YHWH are simply two Hebrew words with exactly the same meaning**.

They are not.

Elohim is a designation for God.

YHWH is the distinctive covenant name of Israel's God.

An analogy can help:

A person may have:

- a personal name;
- a title;
- a description of his position.

Similarly, biblical language can speak about God using His divine name and various descriptions.

Thus:

YHWH identifies the God of Israel.

Elohim identifies Him as God.

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4. YHWH and Adonai

Another major biblical designation is:

Adonai — Lord

The Hebrew root ʾ**-d-n** carries the meaning of lordship, mastery, or authority.

Thus:

YHWH emphasizes the divine name.

Elohim emphasizes God.

Adonai emphasizes Lordship.

These are not three gods.

They are different expressions used in speaking about the one God.

This gives us a powerful theological pattern:

YHWH is God.
YHWH is Lord.
God is Lord.

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5. God and Lord Are Not Opposites

Sometimes the English words create an unnecessary distinction.

Someone may reason:

“God is the Father, but Jesus is Lord.”

But biblical language is more complicated.

The Father is called God.

The Father is also called Lord.

Jesus is called Lord.

And Jesus is also described as God.

Therefore:

“God” and “Lord” are not mutually exclusive titles.

“God” emphasizes **divine identity**.

“Lord” emphasizes **authority and sovereignty**.

The same divine person can therefore be described as both.

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6. The Old Testament Pattern

The Old Testament gives us a remarkable chain:

YHWH → Elohim

YHWH is God.

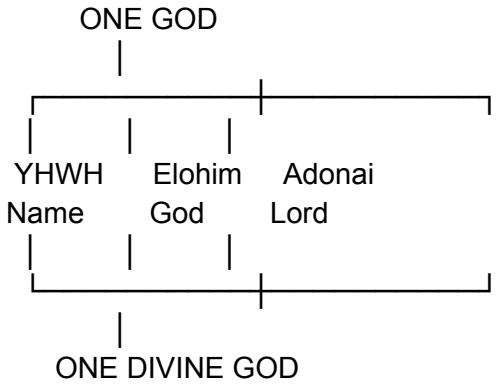
YHWH → Adonai

YHWH is Lord.

Elohim → Lord

God is Lord.

Therefore:



The words are different, but their biblical referent can be the same.

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7. The Greek Bible Changes the Question

The New Testament was written in Greek.

The principal Greek word for God is:

Theos — θεός

The principal Greek word for Lord is:

Kyrios — κύριος

And here we encounter something very important.

In the ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures, **Kyrios** was used to represent the divine name YHWH.

Therefore, for Greek-speaking Jews and Christians, the word **Kyrios** could have a much deeper meaning than merely “master.”

It could refer to:

the Lord—the God of Israel.

This becomes extremely important when the New Testament calls Jesus **Kyrios**.

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8. Jesus Christ Is Lord

The central Christian confession is:

“Jesus Christ is Lord.”

Paul says in Philippians 2:11:

“Every tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.”

The Greek expression is:

Kyrios Iēsous Christos

“Jesus Christ is Lord.”

The statement is much more significant when read against the Old Testament.

Isaiah 45:23 says:

“To me every knee shall bow, every tongue shall swear allegiance.”

The speaker is YHWH.

Philippians 2 applies similar universal language to Jesus.

Thus we have:

Isaiah: Every knee bows before YHWH.

Philippians: Every knee bows and every tongue confesses Jesus Christ as Lord.

This creates a profound connection between **YHWH's universal sovereignty** and **Jesus' universal lordship**.

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9. “My Lord and My God”

Perhaps the clearest New Testament statement occurs after the resurrection.

Thomas sees the risen Jesus and says:

“My Lord and my God!”
— John 20:28

Notice the two titles:

My Lord — Kyrios

My God — Theos

Thomas does not merely call Jesus “Lord.”

He calls Him:

“My Lord and my God.”

This is one of the most direct confessions concerning Jesus' identity in the New Testament.

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10. YHWH → Kyrios → Jesus

Now we can see the larger biblical pattern.

Old Testament Hebrew

YHWH

↓

Greek Old Testament

Kyrios

↓

New Testament

Jesus is Kyrios

This does not mean that every occurrence of *kyrios* automatically means YHWH.

The Greek word can simply mean “lord,” “master,” or “sir.”

But when New Testament writers use Old Testament passages concerning YHWH and apply them to Jesus, the connection becomes highly significant.

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11. Joel and Romans: “Call on the Name of the Lord”

Joel 2:32 says:

“Everyone who calls on the name of YHWH shall be saved.”

The Hebrew text uses **YHWH**.

Paul quotes this in Romans 10:13:

“Everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.”

The surrounding context is about Jesus.

Romans 10:9 says:

“If you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord...”

Therefore, Paul's argument brings together:

YHWH

Lord

Jesus

Salvation

This is one of the most important passages for understanding the significance of Jesus' Lordship.

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12. The Shema and Jesus

The deepest connection may be found by comparing **Deuteronomy 6:4** with **1 Corinthians 8:6**.

The Shema declares:

“YHWH our God, YHWH is one.”

Paul writes:

“For us there is one God, the Father... and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom are all things.”

Paul does not abandon Jewish monotheism.

Instead, he speaks of the one God while placing Jesus within the framework of the one Lord.

This is why 1 Corinthians 8:6 has played such an important role in Christian Christology.

It raises a profound question:

How can Jesus be distinguished from the Father and yet be included within the confession of the one God?

The New Testament does not solve this by denying Jesus' divinity.

Instead, it maintains both:

distinction
and
divine status.

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13. One God, One Lord

The phrase **“one God and one Lord”** should therefore not be understood as:

God = Father
Lord = Jesus
therefore Jesus is not God.

That conclusion is contradicted by passages such as John 1:1 and John 20:28.

Rather, Paul can distinguish:

the Father as God

and

Jesus Christ as Lord

while other New Testament texts explicitly describe Jesus in divine terms.

This is part of the remarkable theological development of the New Testament.

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14. John 1: “The Word Was God”

John begins his Gospel with:

“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.”

The Greek uses **Theos** for God.

Then John says:

“The Word became flesh.”

The Word is therefore associated with Jesus Christ.

The passage maintains both:

The Word was with God.

The Word was God.

There is distinction without simply dividing God into two gods.

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15. “God Is Lord and Lord Is God”

Your statement:

“Lord is God and God is Lord.”

can therefore express a genuine biblical truth **if it is understood theologically rather than as a claim that the Hebrew words are lexical synonyms**.

The Bible teaches:

YHWH is Elohim.

YHWH is Lord.

God is Lord.

And the New Testament teaches:

Jesus is Lord.

Jesus is described as God.

The great question is therefore not whether “God” and “Lord” are two completely separate categories.

They are not.

The deeper question is:

How does the New Testament include Jesus within the divine Lordship of the one God while maintaining His distinction from the Father?

That is the heart of New Testament Christology.

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16. A Biblical Identity–Authority Framework

We can summarize the terminology this way:

Term	Language	Primary emphasis
Elohim	Hebrew	God / deity
YHWH	Hebrew	Divine covenant name
Adonai	Hebrew	Lord / sovereign
Theos	Greek	God / deity
Kyrios	Greek	Lord / master / sovereign
Jesus Christ	New Testament	Messiah, Son, Lord

The terms should not be collapsed into one another lexically.

But they can converge in their **reference to the one God and His sovereign identity**.

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17. The Central Mystery of Christian Faith

The Christian confession eventually becomes:

There is one God.

Yet:

The Father is God.

The Son is God.

The Holy Spirit is God.

And:

The Father is not the Son.

The Son is not the Spirit.

This is the theological framework that later Christianity expressed as the **Trinity**.

The word “Trinity” itself is not a biblical word, but the doctrine attempts to articulate the biblical data.

The Old Testament establishes the foundation of divine unity.

The New Testament introduces the remarkable revelation concerning the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

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18. The Significance of “Our God”

There is also something deeply personal in the phrase:

“YHWH our God.”

The biblical confession is not simply:

“There is a God.”

It is:

“He is our God.”

The God who is YHWH is the God who enters covenant relationship with His people.

Therefore:

YHWH — His identity.

Elohim — His deity.

Adonai — His sovereignty.

Our God — His covenant relationship with His people.

This gives the phrase “the LORD our God” enormous theological and relational depth.

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19. Jesus as “Our Lord”

The New Testament takes this covenantal language further.

Christians repeatedly speak of:

“our Lord Jesus Christ.”

Paul's letters use this expression extensively.

The believer therefore does not merely acknowledge Jesus as an historical figure.

The Christian confession is:

Jesus is our Lord.

This means allegiance, submission, trust, worship, and faith in Him.

The confession is simultaneously personal and theological.

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20. The Deepest Connection

We can now express the central idea more precisely:

YHWH is Elohim.

YHWH is Adonai.

Elohim is Lord.

The Lord is God.

And in the New Testament:

Jesus is Kyrios.

Jesus is Theos.

Therefore, the statement:

“Jesus Christ is Lord”

must be understood against the entire biblical background of God's identity and sovereignty.

It is not merely a statement that Jesus is a ruler.

It is a confession that the crucified and risen Jesus has been exalted as **Lord**, in a theological environment where **Lordship belongs uniquely and supremely to the God of Israel**.

Conclusion

The words **Elohim, YHWH, Adonai, Theos, and Kyrios** are not interchangeable dictionary entries. Each has its own linguistic history and semantic range.

Yet together they reveal a profound biblical pattern.

Elohim speaks of God.

YHWH identifies the God of Israel.

Adonai expresses His lordship.

Theos is the principal New Testament word for God.

Kyrios expresses lordship and, in scriptural contexts, can represent the divine Lord.

The Old Testament declares:

YHWH is Elohim.

The Old Testament also declares:

YHWH is Lord.

The New Testament then makes the extraordinary confession:

Jesus Christ is Lord.

And Thomas addresses the risen Jesus:

“My Lord and my God.”

Therefore, the deepest biblical issue is not simply the difference between the words **God** and **Lord**.

The deeper issue is the identity of the **one God**, His divine name, His sovereignty, and the astonishing place of **Jesus Christ within that divine identity and lordship**.

The biblical journey moves from:

YHWH — Elohim — Adonai

to

Theos — Kyrios — Jesus Christ.

And at the center of the Christian confession stands the declaration:

Jesus Christ is Lord.